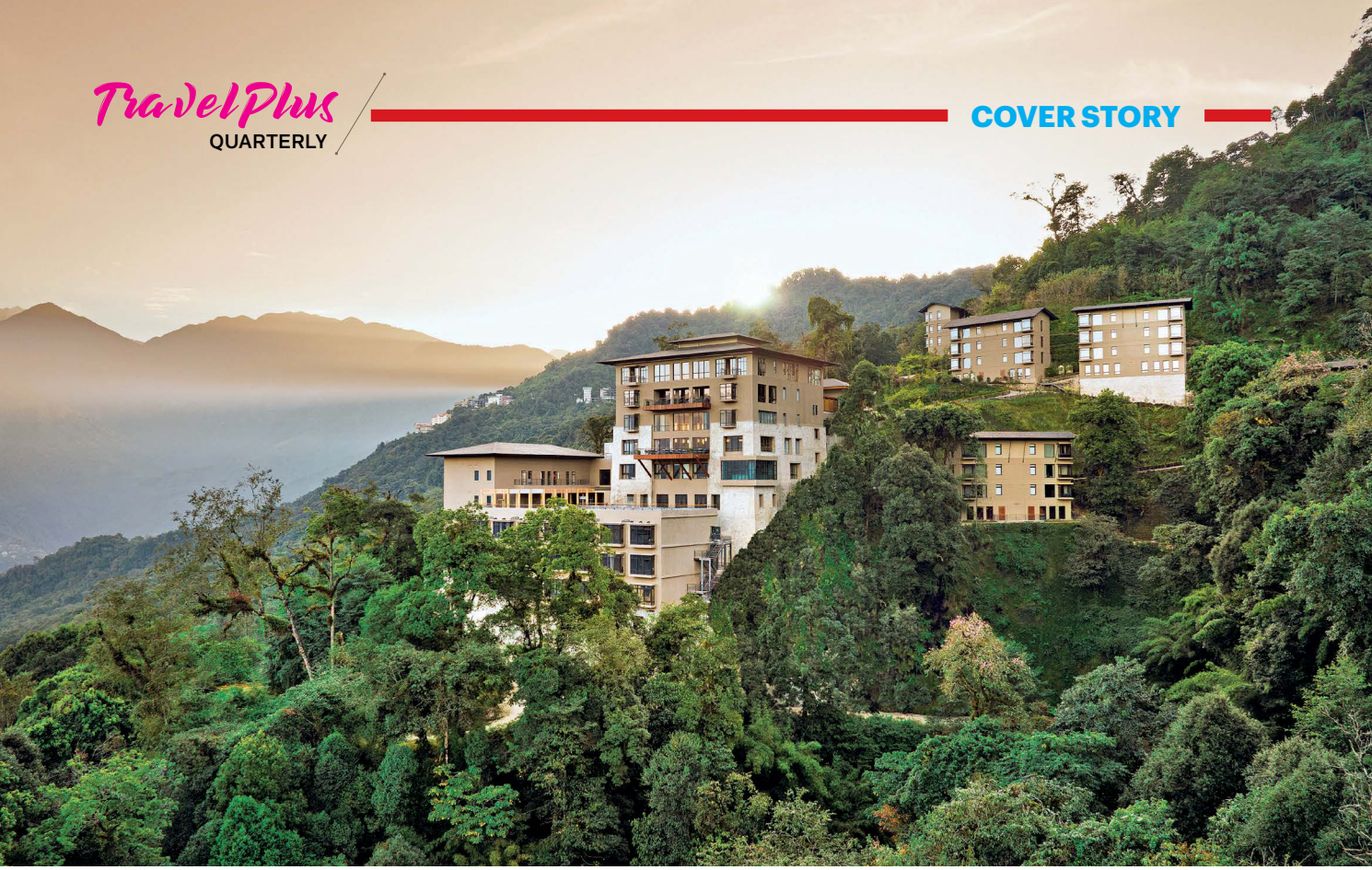




EMBEDDED INTO THE HILLS
Top, The Taj Guras Kutir seen from a distance; above, its atmospherically lit courtyard at dusk

On another day, Gangtok's pedestrian-friendly MG Road, which the locals describe as "our Mall Road", makes for a pleasant amble. Local Nepali restaurants coexist with contemporary cafés, and impeccably dressed young women, monks on an errand, and young men with gelled hair are everywhere. But it is towards the higher reaches that Gangtok breathes easier. Taste the morning air at the Enchey Monastery resounding with the chants of the monks, or the open-air zoo, spread out over a forested hillside, conveying hardly any sense of the animals being in enclosures. The famous snow leopard is no more, but it is delightful to see the lovable red panda.

The hotel organises a trip to Rumtek monastery (24 km away), Sikkim's largest monastery. Rumtek's stature arises from being the seat-in-exile of the 16th Karmapa who built it in 1966. A repository of religious and cultural heritage, the beautiful white Gompa on a hilltop is a serene place to be in, even as young monks go about their studies or prayers, chatting like in any boys' hostel. The holy relics of the 16th Karmapa are kept in a golden stupa. The Buddha presides over offerings of fruit, food and unexpected packets of Haldiram chips, Bikaner *bhujia* and Real fruit juice.

The final day, as on every morning, I wake up to an alarm strategically set to catch the morning light falling on the Kanchenjunga—*if* she so pleases. She does. I run out of the room, unmindful of the cold, and meet the mountains, their snow shining with serene ferocity across the forested valleys. In Satyajit Ray's *Kanchenjunga*, the peak remains hidden as the plot unfolds and reveals itself finally when the protagonists have made the right choices and feel content. I, too, have communed with leopard poo and the sound of running brooks, and read a juicy murder mystery while chewing flaky croissants. Kanchenjunga had no choice but to reveal herself. ■